Talking Politics in Private and at Work

Political Interest and the Private Workplace Discussion Gap

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Working paper

Abstract

Political discussion is often studied as an individual propensity or a characteristic of social networks, with less attention to how the same individuals communicate across different relational settings. This paper examines differences in political discussion between private relationships and the workplace, asking whether political engagement translates equally into conversation across these contexts. Using survey data from 8,066 respondents across seven European countries, we compare the frequency of political discussion with family and friends and with work colleagues. We find that political discussion is more frequent in private settings than at work. Political interest is positively associated with discussion in both contexts, but its association is stronger in private relationships, resulting in a wider gap between private and workplace discussion among politically interested individuals. By contrast, cross-cutting friendships are associated with more frequent discussion in both settings without affecting the gap. Other proposed explanations, including perceived political minority status, institutional trust, and dissatisfaction with public services, receive little empirical support. We interpret these findings through the concept of **contextual amplification**: political interest is associated with greater willingness to engage in political conversation, but the extent to which this engagement translates into discussion varies across relational settings. The findings highlight the importance of examining political expression as context-dependent behavior rather than as a stable individual characteristic.

Introduction

Political discussion is a basic way in which citizens encounter public affairs. It helps people exchange information, test arguments, learn what others believe, and connect political questions to daily experience. Most research asks who discusses politics, how discussion networks are composed, or what follows from exposure to agreement and disagreement. These questions are important, but they can make political talk look like a stable personal tendency. Someone is described as politically interested, expressive, conflict-averse, or embedded in a cross-cutting network. The setting in which a conversation occurs is often secondary.

Everyday political expression is more contextual than this picture suggests. A person may talk often about national politics with relatives and friends, yet rarely mention the same subjects to colleagues. This is not an unusual combination. Family and friendship networks tend to contain chosen or long-standing relationships. Workplaces bring together people who may not have selected one another and who must continue coordinating after disagreement. The stakes also differ. A difficult conversation among friends may strain a valued relationship. A difficult conversation at work can affect daily cooperation, belonging, reputation, or expectations about professional judgment. The

workplace is therefore neither wholly private nor fully public. It is a repeated relational setting in which expression can have consequences beyond the conversation itself.

This paper examines the gap between political discussion in private life and at work. We define private discussion as talk about national politics with family and friends. Workplace discussion refers to talk about national politics with colleagues. The private-workplace discussion gap is the within-person difference between these two frequencies. A positive value means that a respondent talks about politics more often in private life than at work. This measure makes the setting comparison explicit. It also separates two questions that otherwise become conflated: what makes people talk about politics in general, and what makes their talk vary across relationships?

The distinction matters for political behaviour. Workplace networks can expose citizens to people they would not otherwise choose as discussion partners. In a foundational study, Mutz and Mondak argue that workplaces are especially well positioned to generate cross-cutting political contact because they combine social interaction with relatively weak choice over network composition (Mutz and Mondak 2006). Estlund similarly presents workplace ties as an important form of contact across social divisions (Estlund 2005). If politics is routinely avoided at work, the workplace may still bring diverse citizens together, but less of that diversity becomes visible through discussion. If politics is discussed, the same setting may support learning and tolerance. It may also produce tension or incivility. The democratic promise of workplace contact cannot be inferred from contact alone.

The distinction also matters for research on silence. People do not simply decide whether to hold or reveal a political opinion in the abstract. They anticipate an audience, a relationship, and possible consequences. Research on selective disclosure shows that people manage political information within their discussion networks and avoid subjects that could make interaction turn hostile (Cowan and Baldassarri 2018). Work on opting out of political discussion reaches a similar conclusion. Avoidance is patterned by expectations about disagreement and by the perceived costs of conversational engagement (Settle and Carlson 2019; Carlson and Settle 2022). The spiral-of-silence tradition places perceived opinion support and fear of isolation at the centre of expression decisions (Noelle-Neumann 1974; Glynn, Hayes, and Shanahan 1997). Preference-falsification theory extends this logic by showing how a gap between private views and public expression can persist when people anticipate social sanctions (Kuran 1995). These traditions differ in level and scope, but they share a relational insight: speech depends on where it occurs and who is expected to hear it.

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We use the complete PEPS-Y Wave 1 data to compare private and workplace political discussion. The survey asks respondents how often they discuss national political matters with family or friends and with work colleagues. Both items use the same seven-point response scale. This allows a direct within-person comparison among respondents who have colleagues. The analysis was preregistered around political interest, perceived political minority status, cross-cutting friendships, institutional trust, public-service experiences, and an additional gender-by-migration-status hypothesis.

The main empirical pattern is clear. Respondents report discussing national politics more often with family and friends than with colleagues. Political interest is strongly associated with talk in both settings. Its association is larger in private life, so interest also widens the private-workplace gap. Cross-cutting friendships predict more talk in both settings, but their association with the gap is effectively zero. The other preregistered mechanisms do not show their expected gap patterns. Wave 1 therefore supports a narrower argument than a broad theory of workplace social risk would

imply.

The paper develops this narrower account as contextual amplification. Political interest increases the motivation and cognitive availability needed for political conversation. The workplace does not eliminate this relationship. Interested respondents talk more there too. Yet the increase is weaker than in private settings. One interpretation is that workplace constraints cap the expression of political motivation. This is consistent with social-risk reasoning, but it does not prove that perceived sanctions are the causal mechanism. The measures of minority position, cross-cutting friendship, and trust do not together support such a general claim.

The contribution is therefore conceptual and empirical. Conceptually, the paper treats political talk as a relationship-specific behaviour rather than a single individual propensity. Empirically, it shows why parallel outcome models and a within-person difference are useful. A predictor can increase political discussion everywhere while still widening the gap between settings. It can also affect both settings without changing the gap. This comparative design makes those patterns visible. The paper proceeds by developing the relational distinction, presenting the preregistered expectations, describing Wave 1 and the models, and then assessing what the results do and do not support.

Political discussion across relational settings

Private networks and relational security

Private political discussion usually occurs within relationships that carry accumulated knowledge. Family members and friends often know one another's histories, values, and habitual reactions. This familiarity does not guarantee agreement. It can even make disagreement sharper because political claims connect to identity and shared experience. Still, familiarity provides information about how much disagreement a relationship can absorb. Speakers can anticipate whether a topic is safe, whether humour is appropriate, and whether a conflict will persist after the conversation.

Private networks also contain more opportunities for selection. People do not choose all relatives, and friendships are never selected only on politics. Yet friendship networks can be formed, maintained, or allowed to fade in ways that employment relationships often cannot. Political discussion itself may contribute to this selection. People can avoid certain friends, reserve politics for others, or learn which subjects should be left alone. Carlson and Settle describe political discussion as a process of navigating not only opinions but also social relationships (Carlson and Settle 2022). Cowan and Baldassarri show that disclosure varies across ties. People selectively reveal attitudes when they expect receptiveness and conceal them when they anticipate conflict (Cowan and Baldassarri 2018).

These features make private talk a useful baseline, but not an unproblematic space of authentic expression. Family norms can silence dissent. Close relationships can impose strong emotional costs. Preference falsification can occur around a dinner table as well as in a public meeting. Our argument does not equate private settings with truth and workplaces with falsehood. It treats the two settings as different opportunity structures. On average, trusted and chosen ties offer more relational security and more information about conversational boundaries. That should make political talk easier to sustain.

The workplace as a semi-public setting

Workplaces combine regular interaction with incomplete relational choice. Colleagues may spend substantial time together, coordinate complex tasks, and develop friendship. At the same time, many cannot easily leave a team or replace a discussion partner after conflict. Political conversations enter relationships that have another primary purpose. The need to work together remains even when the conversation reveals disagreement.

This combination makes the workplace politically important. Mutz and Mondak find that workplace discussion is especially likely to cross political lines (Mutz and Mondak 2006). The workplace brings together people with different experiences and views, while families and voluntary groups may be more homogeneous. Exposure to disagreement can improve awareness of the reasons behind opposing positions and may foster tolerance. Estlund argues that workplace bonds can support a diverse democracy because they create sustained contact among people who would otherwise remain socially separated (Estlund 2005).

The same features that create cross-cutting contact may also discourage disclosure. Weak choice over partners means that a conversational mistake is harder to escape. Repeated interaction means that impressions can persist. Organisational hierarchies introduce uncertainty about how political speech will be interpreted. Even without formal sanctions, workers may worry that an opinion will alter expectations about competence, trustworthiness, or group loyalty. A conversation can also affect bystanders. Experience-sampling evidence links political conversations at work to negative affect and reduced job performance on the same day, especially when employees disagree with the views they encounter (Kim et al. 2022). Research on political identity-based incivility connects workplace politics to physical health complaints (Miner et al. 2021). A wider review shows that political ideology can shape organisational attitudes, interpersonal evaluations, and workplace experiences (Swigart et al. 2020).

These findings do not imply that political discussion at work is inherently harmful. They show that its costs and benefits are conditional. A respectful discussion among equals is different from an argument in front of a supervisor. A conversation that reveals unfamiliar reasons can improve understanding. One that signals contempt can damage cooperation. Because workers cannot know the outcome in advance, silence may be a reasonable response to uncertainty.

Organisational scholarship distinguishes employee voice from silence. Silence is not simply the absence of something employees could have said. It can reflect resignation, self-protection, prosocial restraint, or a judgment that speaking will not help (Morrison and Milliken 2000). Later work treats voice and silence as related but distinct choices and stresses that motives matter (Morrison 2023). Political talk is not identical to employee voice about organisational practices. Still, this framework is useful. A worker may avoid politics to protect themself, to protect colleagues, or to preserve a cooperative climate. Observed silence does not identify which motive is active.

From discussion frequency to a contextual gap

Studying private and workplace talk as separate outcomes is necessary but incomplete. Suppose political interest increases both. A workplace model would show that interested people talk more with colleagues. A private model would show the same pattern among friends and family. Neither result alone shows whether the setting matters. Comparing the coefficients helps, but models of two ordinal outcomes are not always directly comparable. A within-person difference provides an additional descriptive summary.

The gap is defined as private discussion frequency minus workplace discussion frequency. It ranges from -6 to 6 on the original seven-point scales. Positive values indicate that private talk is more frequent. Zero means equal reported frequency, and negative values indicate more frequent workplace talk. This measure does not identify self-censorship directly. A positive gap can arise because private talk is unusually common, because workplace talk is unusually rare, or through both processes. That is why we retain all three outcomes.

The three-outcome design has a clear interpretive logic. Predictors that move private and workplace talk together indicate general political engagement. Predictors that are associated mainly with workplace talk are more consistent with setting-specific inhibition or facilitation. Predictors of the gap identify factors that correspond to contextual asymmetry. No single coefficient settles the mechanism. The pattern across outcomes is the evidence.

Political interest and social risk hypotheses

Political interest as motivation

Political discussion requires something to say and a reason to say it. Political interest makes public affairs more salient. Interested citizens follow political information, notice links between events and their own lives, and are more likely to have accessible opinions. Interest should therefore increase political talk across settings.

The contextual question is whether motivation translates equally into expression. In private life, interested people can choose receptive partners and revisit political subjects over time. At work, the same motivation may meet stronger constraints. Norms against discussing politics, uncertainty about colleagues, or concern about disruption can limit expression. Political interest should still predict workplace talk, but less strongly than private talk. If so, interest will widen the private-workplace gap.

This expectation differs from a claim that interested people are especially afraid to speak at work. The proposed asymmetry does not require greater subjective fear among the interested. It requires only that the workplace place a lower ceiling on how much rising motivation becomes observed discussion.

H1a. Political interest is positively associated with private political discussion and workplace political discussion.

H1b. The positive association is stronger for private discussion, producing a larger private-workplace discussion gap.

Perceived minority position

Expression becomes riskier when people believe their view lacks support. The spiral of silence proposes that perceived opinion climates influence willingness to speak because individuals anticipate isolation (Noelle-Neumann 1974). Meta-analytic evidence finds a modest relationship between perceived support and expression (Glynn, Hayes, and Shanahan 1997). Recent work on political self-censorship also shows that silence can reinforce itself when people infer the climate from what others are willing to say (Gibson and Sutherland 2023).

The workplace may sharpen this relationship. Colleagues are recurring audiences, and disagreement can spill into cooperation. Someone who sees their political position as a minority view may avoid

revealing it at work, even if they discuss it in trusted private relationships. This implies lower workplace discussion and a larger gap.

H2a. Perceived political minority status is negatively associated with workplace political discussion.

H2b. Perceived political minority status is positively associated with the private-workplace discussion gap.

Cross-cutting friendships

Cross-cutting friendships can work in more than one direction. Frequent contact with disagreement may build conversational experience. People can learn how to state differences without threatening a relationship. This habituation account predicts more private discussion and less workplace inhibition. Yet cross-cutting ties may also make conflict more salient. People who repeatedly encounter disagreement may learn to avoid political talk rather than become more comfortable with it. Work on discussion avoidance suggests that citizens actively manage such exposure (Settle and Carlson 2019).

The preregistered expectation follows the habituation account. Cross-cutting friendships should increase private talk and reduce the gap by making disagreement easier to manage across contexts.

H3a. Cross-cutting friendships are positively associated with private political discussion.

H3b. Cross-cutting friendships are negatively associated with the private-workplace discussion gap.

Institutional trust

Institutional trust may shape the tone in which politics is understood. Citizens who trust political institutions may see conflict as legitimate and political exchange as worthwhile. Low trust can instead support a grievance orientation in which politics appears corrupt, futile, or morally charged. Such grievances may generate discussion, especially in private settings where complaints are safe. They may be harder to voice at work.

The direction is not theoretically certain. Distrust can motivate people to speak. Trust can also reduce the intensity that makes political talk risky. The preregistration selected the second account for workplace discussion.

H4a. Institutional trust is positively associated with workplace political discussion.

H4b. Institutional trust is negatively associated with the private-workplace discussion gap.

Public-service experiences

Encounters with public services connect politics to everyday life. A poor experience can make questions of government performance personally relevant and conversation-worthy. The most immediate venue for recounting such an experience may be family or friends. Workplace norms may limit how far the resulting complaint becomes political discussion among colleagues.

H5a. Public-service dissatisfaction is positively associated with private political discussion.

H5b. Public-service dissatisfaction is positively associated with the private-workplace discussion gap.

Gender and migration status

The preregistration also proposed that the gap varies across the intersection of gender and migration status. The expectation was that women with a migration background would show a smaller gap because workplace discussion would be relatively more common for them than private discussion. This is a subgroup expectation rather than part of the main five-mechanism model. We therefore assess it in a separate specification.

H7. The private-workplace discussion gap is smaller among women with a migration background.

Data and measurement

Wave 1 sample

The analysis uses the complete PEPS-Y Wave 1 file. It contains 8,066 interviews across Croatia, France, Germany, Italy, Poland, Spain, and Sweden. The sample includes 282 final-instrument early-fieldwork respondents and 7,784 main-field respondents. All 8,066 respondents have a positive combined within-country survey weight, `weight_pilotmain`.

Of the full sample, 6,131 respondents report having work colleagues and 6,113 provide valid responses to both discussion questions. The primary private-talk model includes 8,015 respondents. The workplace model includes 6,131 and the gap model includes 6,113. Outcome nonresponse accounts for the remaining exclusions. The complete-case sensitivity uses 7,410 respondents for private talk, 5,654 for workplace talk, and 5,640 for the gap.

All main specifications include country fixed effects. The present paper estimates pooled associations because the preregistration treats country heterogeneity as an optional descriptive extension. Country-specific mechanisms remain outside the confirmatory tests.

Political discussion outcomes

Private political discussion is measured with a question asking how often the respondent discusses national political matters with relatives or friends. Workplace political discussion uses a parallel question about work colleagues. Both items use a seven-point ordered scale from 1, never, to 7, every day. Respondents may choose a nonresponse option. The workplace item also includes an option for respondents who do not have colleagues.

Private discussion is observed for 8,015 respondents. Workplace discussion is unavailable for 1,935 respondents, including 1,886 who report having no colleagues. Workplace models exclude respondents without colleagues. The gap is calculated only when a respondent has colleagues and valid responses on both discussion items.

The gap is private discussion minus workplace discussion. A respondent who reports a private frequency of 5 and a workplace frequency of 3 has a gap of 2. A respondent who gives the same response in both settings has a gap of 0. The measure retains the distance between the two seven-point items. It is easy to interpret, but it should not be treated as a latent scale. A one-point difference may not have identical meaning at every part of an ordinal response scale. We address this limitation by analysing the original outcomes with ordered models and using the gap as a complementary summary.

Predictors

Political interest is standardised for the models. Higher values represent greater interest. Perceived minority positioning uses the survey item that most directly captures whether respondents see their political opinion as a minority position. The measure is binary in the main model. It is a proxy for perceived expression risk, not a direct measure of expected workplace sanctions.

Cross-cutting friendships are measured by the reported presence of friends with different political views. The measure is standardised. It captures disagreement within friendship networks. It does not show how often those friends discuss politics, how intense their disagreements are, or whether respondents have developed conversational skill.

Institutional trust is represented by a standardised index. Public-service experiences are summarised with a service-quality index and reversed so that higher standardised values indicate greater dissatisfaction. This sign convention makes positive estimates consistent with the preregistered expectation that negative experiences increase political talk.

All main models adjust for age, education, employment status, left-right self-placement, and country fixed effects. These controls were specified before the analysis. They reduce obvious compositional differences, but they do not turn the estimates into causal effects. Political interest, network composition, trust, service evaluations, and discussion behaviour can influence one another. Unmeasured traits may affect them jointly.

The primary analysis follows the deterministic single-imputation strategy used in the Core 1 and Core 2 papers. Missing left-right placement is predicted from political-orientation items with country interactions. Small residual gaps in numeric predictors are replaced with country means, and categorical controls use country modes. Outcomes and survey weights are never imputed. This approach retains a common model sample but does not propagate imputation uncertainty. We therefore report weighted complete-case estimates as a sensitivity analysis.

Descriptive pattern

Figure 1 shows weighted means for private discussion, workplace discussion, and the gap. Mean private discussion is 3.94. Mean workplace discussion among respondents with colleagues is 3.34. The average private-minus-workplace gap is 0.56 scale points. On the original response scale, values near 3 and 4 correspond to discussion occurring between monthly and several times a month. The difference is visible, but it is not a separation between a highly political private sphere and a silent workplace.

The mean also conceals heterogeneity. Some respondents report little discussion in either setting, while others talk often in both. In the weighted four-category summary, 57.8 percent fall into the low-private and low-workplace group. Another 21.6 percent report high discussion in both settings. The group with high private and low workplace discussion accounts for 14.1 percent, while 6.5 percent report low private and high workplace discussion. The average gap therefore reflects broad shifts in frequency and a smaller group with clear contextual separation.

Empirical strategy

The empirical strategy follows the preregistration. Private and workplace discussion remain in their original ordered form for the main outcome models. We estimate survey-weighted ordered-logit regressions with the same five predictors and control variables. The workplace model is restricted

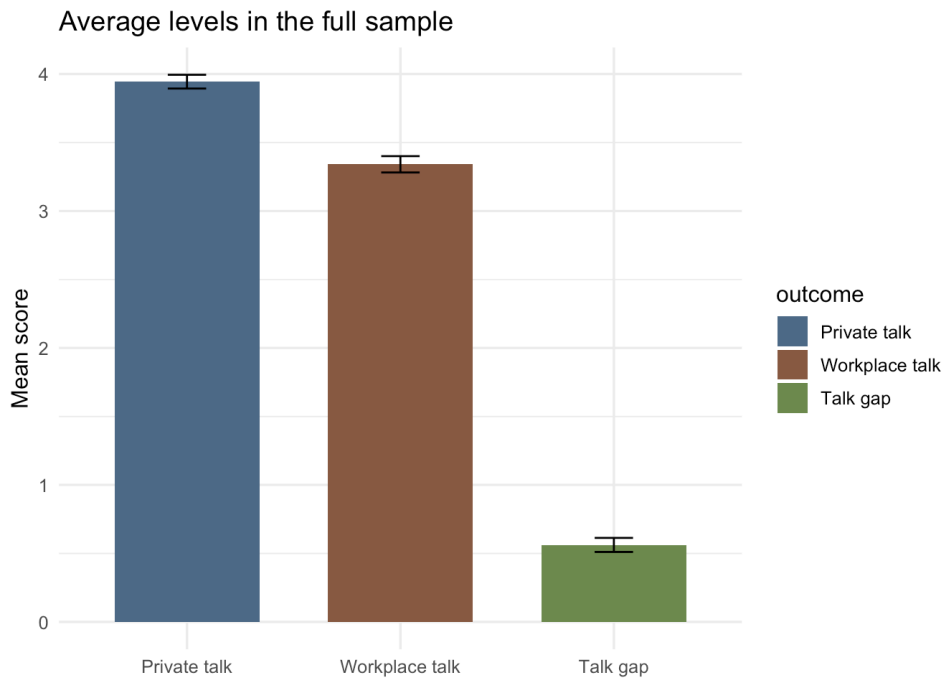


Figure 1: Weighted mean political discussion in private and workplace settings and the mean within-person gap

to respondents with colleagues. Coefficients are reported on the log-odds scale. A positive coefficient means that higher predictor values are associated with a greater likelihood of reporting a higher discussion category, holding the included covariates constant.

The gap model uses survey-weighted ordinary least squares with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. Positive coefficients indicate a wider tendency to talk more in private than at work. Negative coefficients indicate a narrower gap. Because the outcome is a difference of ordinal items, OLS is best understood as a transparent descriptive model. It offers a direct estimate in scale points and complements the ordered models.

The central test of H1 uses the pattern across all three outcomes. Interest should be positive in the private and workplace ordered models. It should also be positive in the gap model. The last condition matters. Two positive outcome coefficients do not by themselves show that interest produces stronger contextual separation.

H2 to H5 are assessed with their preregistered outcome combinations. H2 requires a negative workplace association and a positive gap association. H3 requires more private talk and a smaller gap. H4 requires more workplace talk and a smaller gap. H5 requires more private talk and a larger gap. We report direction, uncertainty, and consistency across outcomes. A result is not treated as supported merely because one estimate points in the expected direction.

The secondary analysis for H7 includes gender, migration background, and their interaction. We report the workplace and gap interaction estimates, as well as the gender main effects that help describe the pattern. Moderation tests examine whether the minority-position association changes with political interest and cross-cutting friendships.

Robustness checks treat private and workplace discussion as approximately continuous and estimate

OLS models. An exploratory typology divides respondents at a value of 5, corresponding to at least weekly discussion, to form four combinations of high and low private and workplace talk. The typology is used only as a descriptive aid. Dichotomisation discards information and does not provide a stronger test than the main models.

We report all preregistered mechanisms irrespective of statistical significance. P-values and confidence intervals describe sampling uncertainty under the fitted model. They are not used as a substitute for evaluating the full pattern of evidence. The complete-case and main-field-only analyses test whether the conclusions depend on deterministic imputation or inclusion of the early-fieldwork respondents.

Results

Main associations

Table 1 presents the five preregistered predictors across private discussion, workplace discussion, and the gap. Figure 2 shows the same coefficients with confidence intervals. The two ordered-logit columns and the OLS gap column use different scales. Comparisons should focus on direction, uncertainty, and the presence of a gap association rather than on the raw difference between log-odds coefficients.

Table 1: Main models of private discussion, workplace discussion, and the private-workplace gap

Predictor	**Private talk**	**Workplace talk**	**Talk gap**
Political interest	1.275	0.890	0.192
	[1.225, 1.325]	[0.838, 0.943]	[0.143, 0.242]
	$p < .001$	$p < .001$	$p < .001$
Political-opinion minority	0.203	0.196	-0.054
	[0.031, 0.376]	[0.002, 0.391]	[-0.290, 0.182]
	$p = .021$	$p = .048$	$p = .654$
Cross-cutting friendships	0.161	0.132	0.000
	[0.120, 0.202]	[0.087, 0.180]	[-0.050, 0.051]
	$p < .001$	$p < .001$	$p = .990$
Institutional trust	-0.008	0.027	-0.020
	[-0.065, 0.050]	[-0.038, 0.093]	[-0.093, 0.053]
	$p = .788$	$p = .425$	$p = .590$
Public-service dissatisfaction	0.053	0.049	0.016
	[-0.003, 0.109]	[-0.015, 0.113]	[-0.053, 0.085]
	$p = .064$	$p = .131$	$p = .651$

Notes. Private and workplace coefficients are weighted ordered-logit estimates. Gap coefficients are weighted OLS estimates with robust standard errors. All models include age, education, employment status, left-right placement, and country fixed effects. Predictors and controls use deterministic single imputation; outcomes and weights are not imputed. Ninety-five percent confidence intervals are in brackets. Model samples are 8,015 for private talk, 6,131 for workplace talk, and 6,113 for the gap.

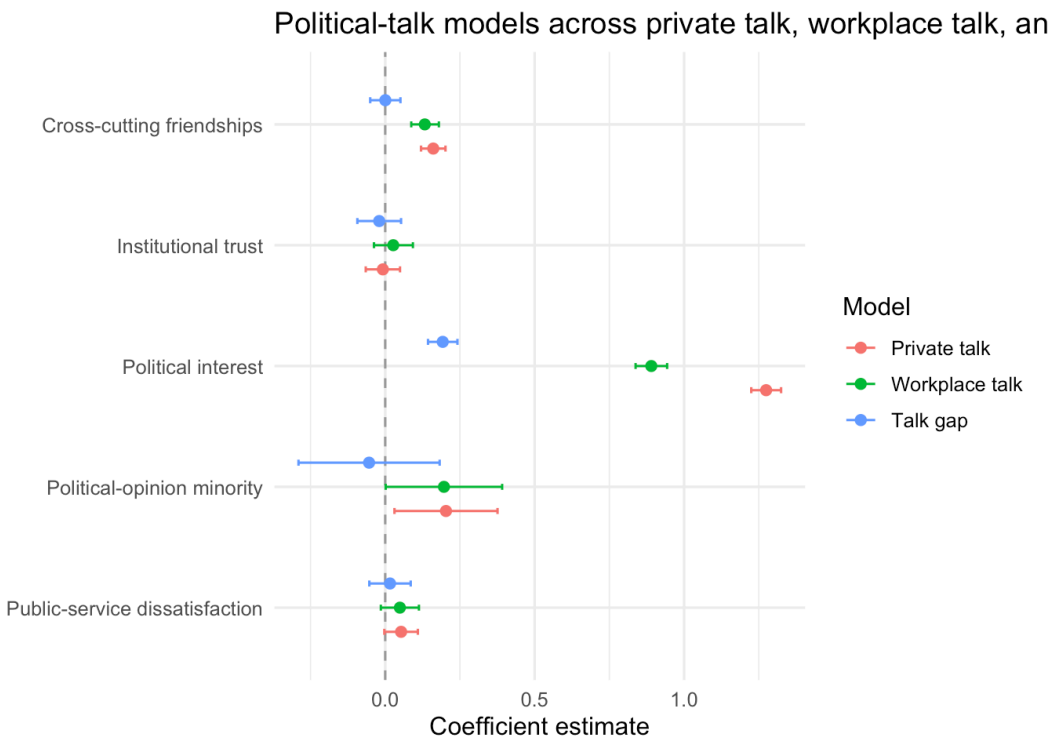


Figure 2: Coefficient estimates across private discussion, workplace discussion, and the talk gap

Political interest is the strongest and most consistent predictor. A one-standard-deviation increase in interest is associated with a 1.275 increase in the log odds of reporting a higher private discussion category, with a 95 percent confidence interval from 1.225 to 1.325. The workplace estimate is also positive and precise at 0.890, with a confidence interval from 0.838 to 0.943. Interested respondents talk more in both settings.

The gap model provides the key contextual result. Political interest is associated with a 0.192-point wider private-minus-workplace gap. The confidence interval runs from 0.143 to 0.242, and $p < .001$. This is not a claim that interest causes workplace reticence. The workplace association remains strongly positive. Rather, political discussion rises more sharply in private life than at work as interest increases. H1a and H1b are supported.

Perceived political minority status does not show the pattern expected under H2. The workplace coefficient is positive at 0.196, with a confidence interval from 0.002 to 0.391. The gap coefficient is -0.054, with a confidence interval from -0.290 to 0.182. Respondents who identify their political opinion as a minority position do not report less workplace talk or a wider gap. H2 is not supported.

Cross-cutting friendships predict more discussion in both settings. The private coefficient is 0.161, and the workplace coefficient is 0.132. Both are precise. The gap estimate is effectively zero at 0.000, with a confidence interval from -0.050 to 0.051. H3a is supported, but H3b is not. Cross-cutting friendships appear to mark general conversational engagement rather than a narrower private-workplace gap.

Institutional trust is close to zero in all three models. The workplace estimate is 0.027, with a confidence interval from -0.038 to 0.093. The gap estimate is -0.020, with a confidence interval

from -0.093 to 0.053. H4 is not supported.

Public-service dissatisfaction is weak in all three models. The private estimate is 0.053, with a confidence interval from -0.003 to 0.109 and p = .064. The gap estimate is 0.016, with a confidence interval from -0.053 to 0.085. The full sample does not support either part of H5.

Hypothesis assessment

Table 2 summarises the preregistered assessment. An expectation is marked as supported only when the relevant outcome pattern is present and the estimates are sufficiently precise to distinguish it from zero. Mixed means that only part of the preregistered pattern is present.

Table 2: Preregistered hypothesis assessment in Wave 1

H	Expectation	Assessment	Evidence
H1	Interest increases talk in both settings and widens the gap.	Supported	Private 1.275, workplace 0.890, gap 0.192; all three estimates are positive and precise.
H2	Minority position reduces workplace talk and widens the gap.	Not supported	Workplace 0.196 and gap -0.054; both directions contradict the expectation.
H3	Cross-cutting friendships increase private talk and narrow the gap.	Mixed	Private 0.161 is positive and precise; gap 0.000 does not narrow.
H4	Trust increases workplace talk and narrows the gap.	Not supported	Workplace 0.027 and gap -0.020; both estimates are imprecise.
H5	Service dissatisfaction increases private talk and widens the gap.	Not supported	Private 0.053 and gap 0.016; neither estimate is precise.
H7	Women with a migration background have a smaller gap.	Not supported	Gap interaction -0.094, p = .637; workplace interaction 0.005, p = .980.

The table makes the narrower empirical story visible. Political engagement travels across settings, but unequally. Cross-cutting friendships also travel across settings, with no corresponding change in the gap. The social-risk indicators do not form a coherent block of supported effects. The minority-position estimates even run against the preregistered directions. Treating every association as evidence for a single mechanism would overstate what Wave 1 shows.

Robustness and exploratory analyses

Missing data and field phase

The complete-case sensitivity retains 7,410 respondents for private talk, 5,654 for workplace talk, and 5,640 for the gap. Political interest remains positive in the private model (1.228), workplace model (0.852), and gap model (0.191), with $p < .001$ in each case. Cross-cutting friendships remain positive for both discussion outcomes and close to zero for the gap. The other preregistered gap associations remain unsupported. The conclusions therefore do not depend on deterministic single imputation.

Excluding the 282 early-fieldwork respondents also leaves the pattern unchanged. In the main-field-only analysis, the political-interest estimates are 1.277 for private talk, 0.891 for workplace talk, and 0.192 for the gap. Cross-cutting friendships again predict both discussion outcomes but not the gap. The combined Wave 1 analysis is therefore retained as primary.

Functional form

The preregistration proposed OLS checks for the two seven-point discussion outcomes. These models treat the response scales as approximately continuous. Their purpose is to assess whether the substantive conclusions depend on ordered-logit functional form. The main pattern is stable. Political interest remains positively associated with both outcomes and the gap. The private association remains larger. The broader social-risk predictors remain weak or inconsistent. The robustness exercise therefore supports the interpretation of H1 without changing the assessment of H2 to H5.

This stability should not be read as evidence that the scales are truly interval. Ordered models remain preferable for the original outcomes. The OLS results are useful because they place private talk, workplace talk, and their difference on a common scale. Agreement across specifications reduces concern that the main conclusion is an artefact of the ordered link function.

Minority-position moderation

The moderation analysis asks whether minority positioning has different associations among respondents with greater political interest or more cross-cutting friendships. The minority-by-interest interaction is weak in both the workplace and gap models. The workplace interaction is -0.152 with $p = .181$. The gap interaction is -0.130 with $p = .318$. Wave 1 gives no indication that political interest systematically changes the minority-position association.

The minority-by-cross-cutting-friendships interaction is more pronounced. In the workplace model, the interaction is -0.377, with a 95 percent confidence interval from -0.572 to -0.182 and $p < .001$. The gap interaction is 0.131, with a confidence interval from -0.106 to 0.369 and $p = .279$. Among respondents who see their political position as a minority view, the otherwise positive association between cross-cutting friendships and workplace talk is weaker. The evidence does not establish a wider gap.

This pattern could reflect learning about the costs of disagreement rather than learning how to manage it. People with cross-cutting friends may have more direct evidence that political discussion can strain relationships. It could also arise from measurement or subgroup composition. The interaction was preregistered, but the workplace result alone does not justify a revised causal story.

Gender and migration status

The separate H7 model shows a clear gender main effect. Women report less workplace political discussion, with an ordered-logit coefficient of -0.803 and $p < .001$. They also have a larger private-workplace gap, with an OLS coefficient of 0.359 and $p < .001$. These results describe an average gender difference conditional on the model controls.

The woman-by-migration-background interaction is close to zero. In the workplace model, it is 0.005, with a confidence interval from -0.363 to 0.372 and $p = .980$. In the gap model, it is -0.094, with a confidence interval from -0.484 to 0.296 and $p = .637$. H7 is not supported. The data support attention to an average gender difference more clearly than the specific intersectional hypothesis.

Discussion-pattern typology

The exploratory typology helps show what the average gap contains. A threshold of 5 on the original scale identifies respondents who discuss politics at least weekly. In the weighted distribution, 57.8 percent report low discussion in both settings. Another 21.6 percent report high discussion in both. The high-private and low-workplace group accounts for 14.1 percent, while 6.5 percent show the reverse pattern.

This distribution supports two observations. First, contextual suppression is not the only reason workplace talk is infrequent. Many people rarely discuss politics anywhere. Second, a meaningful minority shows the pattern that motivates the paper most directly. These respondents are politically conversational in private life but not at work. The typology is descriptive. Its categories depend on the threshold, and the low-private high-workplace group is too small for stable category-specific modelling.

Discussion and conclusion

Wave 1 reveals a consistent difference between political discussion in private life and at work. Respondents with colleagues report talking about national politics more often with family and friends. The weighted average gap is 0.56 points on a seven-point scale. This difference is not simply a contrast between silence at work and constant discussion at home. Most respondents report low discussion in both settings, while about one fifth report high discussion in both. The within-person shift is nevertheless systematic enough to require explanation.

Political interest provides the clearest account in the present data. Interested respondents talk more with both private ties and colleagues. The workplace is not detached from ordinary political engagement. Still, the association is weaker there. As interest rises, private discussion increases more than workplace discussion, and the gap widens. This is the paper's central result.

We describe this pattern as contextual amplification. Political interest supplies motivation, attention, and accessible political content. Private relationships allow more of that motivation to become conversation. Workplace relationships appear to constrain the increase. The interpretation is relational rather than dispositional. It does not classify interested people as unusually silent at work. They are more talkative than less interested people in both settings. The relevant comparison is how much of the difference associated with interest appears in each context.

This finding extends research on workplace political discussion. Mutz and Mondak show that workplaces can support cross-cutting discourse (Mutz and Mondak 2006). Our results indicate that this opportunity is unevenly used. Workplaces may expose people to dissimilar others while still limiting the frequency with which politics is discussed. The distinction between contact and expression matters. Citizens can work alongside political difference without knowing much about colleagues" views.

The result also connects discussion research to selective disclosure. People manage political information across their relationships (Cowan and Baldassarri 2018; Carlson and Settle 2022). A private-workplace gap is one observable trace of that management. It cannot tell us whether a respondent consciously withholds a view, waits for an invitation, follows a workplace norm, or simply lacks conversational opportunity. Direct measures of disclosure choices and anticipated sanctions are needed to identify those processes.

The broader preregistered social-risk account is not supported. Perceived minority status corre-

sponds to slightly more discussion in both ordered models and does not widen the gap. Institutional trust is not clearly related to workplace talk or the gap. Cross-cutting friendships predict more talk in both settings, but not a narrower gap. These results caution against treating workplace silence as the straightforward product of perceived ideological isolation.

Public-service dissatisfaction is weak in all three models. The positive private-talk estimate is small and its confidence interval includes zero. The full Wave 1 data therefore do not reproduce the stronger private-talk association observed in the pilot analysis.

The moderation results reinforce the need for caution. Among perceived political minorities, the positive association between cross-cutting friendships and workplace talk is weaker. The corresponding gap interaction is imprecise. One possibility is that cross-cutting ties teach restraint by making disagreement costs visible. Another is that the friendship item combines very different experiences, from respectful exchange to repeated conflict. Richer measures are needed before revising the theory around this interaction.

The gender pattern also deserves attention. Women report less workplace political discussion and a larger gap. The interaction with migration background is close to zero. The Wave 1 results therefore support an average gender difference, not the preregistered intersectional prediction.

Several limitations bound the conclusions. The data are cross-sectional. Political interest may increase discussion, but discussion can also sustain interest. Network composition can shape expression, and expression can shape networks. The included controls do not resolve these reciprocal relationships. The models should therefore be read as descriptive associations.

Deterministic single imputation does not propagate uncertainty about replaced values. The weighted complete-case estimates lead to the same substantive conclusions, but this agreement is a sensitivity check rather than a validation of the imputation procedure. The country fixed effects absorb average country differences. They do not test whether workplace norms, labour institutions, and political climates change the size or predictors of the gap.

The dependent variables are self-reported frequencies. Respondents may interpret discussion differently across relationships or countries. They may also report what feels socially appropriate. The matched item wording improves comparability, but it does not remove these concerns. Diary methods or experience sampling could observe conversations closer to when they occur.

The gap measure is transparent but incomplete. Difference scores combine two outcomes and can conceal distinct pathways. The same gap can arise from high private and moderate workplace talk or from moderate private and very low workplace talk. Our three-outcome design addresses this problem partly. Future work could model the paired ordinal responses jointly and distinguish participation, frequency, and disclosure content.

The measures of mechanism are indirect. Perceived political minority status is not the same as expected workplace sanction. Cross-cutting friendships do not measure discussion skill. Institutional trust does not capture whether colleagues are trusted. Wave 1 is therefore better at showing contextual asymmetry than at identifying why it occurs.

Future waves can improve the design in several ways. Direct questions can ask whether respondents avoid political topics at work, what consequences they anticipate, and whether colleagues" views are known. Vignettes can vary hierarchy, group composition, and the observability of speech. Dyadic or repeated-interaction studies can examine how asking, disclosure, and silence respond to prior disagreement. These extensions follow the relational logic developed in recent proposals on political

information and silence. They should be treated as prospective tests, not as explanations already demonstrated by Wave 1.

The paper's practical implication is modest. More workplace political talk is not automatically better. Political conversations can support learning and tolerance, but they can also impose stress and damage cooperation (Kim et al. 2022; Miner et al. 2021). Silence can protect a relationship or conceal disagreement that would be useful to understand. The relevant question is when people can speak without unreasonable social or professional cost.

The Wave 1 results clarify where that question begins. Political talk is not a single behaviour carried unchanged from one relationship to another. Interested citizens speak more across contexts, yet their political engagement is amplified in private life. The workplace remains a distinct conversational setting. Explaining that distinction requires measures of relationships, anticipated consequences, and disclosure choices. Wave 1 does not settle those mechanisms. It shows that the gap is systematic, that political interest is central to it, and that a broad social-risk account needs sharper tests.

Appendix

Sample restrictions and missingness

Table 3: Missingness and primary handling for outcomes and selected covariates

Variable	Total	Missing	Primary handling
Political discussion gap	8,066	1,953	Not imputed; requires colleagues and both outcomes
Workplace political discussion	8,066	1,935	Not imputed; respondents without colleagues excluded
Left-right placement	8,066	576	Regression imputation with country interactions
Private political discussion	8,066	51	Not imputed
Political interest	8,066	51	Country-mean completion
Gender	8,066	43	Country-mean completion
Migration background	8,066	40	Country-mean completion
Institutional trust	8,066	36	Country-mean completion
Employment status	8,066	28	Country-mode completion
Education	8,066	17	Country-mode completion

Secondary interaction estimates

Table 4: Secondary moderation and subgroup interaction estimates

Model	Interaction	Estimate	95 percent CI	p
Workplace talk	Minority by interest	-0.152	[-0.374, 0.071]	.181

Model	Interaction	Estimate	95 percent CI	p
Talk gap	Minority by interest	-0.130	[-0.385, 0.125]	.318
Workplace talk	Minority by cross-cutting	-0.377	[-0.572, -0.182]	$< .001$
Talk gap	Minority by cross-cutting	0.131	[-0.106, 0.369]	.279
Workplace talk	Woman by migrant background	0.005	[-0.363, 0.372]	.980
Talk gap	Woman by migrant background	-0.094	[-0.484, 0.296]	.637

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